diehard Tottenham and he used to take me to White Hart Lane. Every Christmas, I'd end up with a United uniform and a Tottenham uniform, and maybe an England uniform from my mum. If it was soccer—or anything to do with soccer—I was there.

Mum wasn't all that keen on soccer. Her dad was, though, which was one of the reasons I loved being with him as much as I did. Joe was employed in the print trade. For a long time he was over the road from home, at the Stationery Office in Islington. Then he moved down to Fleet Street. He and my grandmother, Peggy, lived on an estate just off City Road, down near Old Street. My dad went out to work early most Saturdays. The rest of us would get on the train at Walthamstow and go down to see my grandparents for the day. We had to get there before noon: Grandad would be off about half past eleven if he was going to watch Spurs. Before leaving, he'd come downstairs and watch me play soccer in the little park on the estate. I'm sure Grandad remembers those times: he definitely remembers me breaking his spectacles. I was only about six but I was already kicking a ball hard enough that his glasses didn't stand a chance the time I accidentally caught him full in the face.

Once Joe went off to White Hart Lane, Peggy would take us off to the shops. Sometimes we'd go to the West End but, more often, we'd get the bus up to the Angel and go to Chapel Market. I didn't mind at all. I had to follow Mum and Nan and my sisters around for a bit, but I always seemed to wangle a toy or something by the end of the afternoon. We sometimes had pie and mash for lunch in Chapel Street as well. Once we got back to the flat, Joe would be getting in from soccer. Then he'd get ready to go out and do the night shift. Dad would pick us up in Wenlock Street after finishing work and we'd all drive home together.

Once I started to get serious about playing soccer, Joe and Peggy would come over to us on Sunday morning. Grandad came and watched all my games. I liked him being there: he was softer with me than Dad when it came to talking about the match and how I'd played. Mum wanted to come too, so Peggy would stay at our house. She'd look after Lynne and have Sunday dinner ready when we all came in. Then, Sunday afternoons, we often went down to Victoria Park in Hackney. There was plenty of open space to play soccer with Dad and Grandad, and there were lots of other things to do as well: a big playground, the boating lake and even a little zoo.

I couldn't have asked for anything more and I didn't, but along came Ridgeway Rovers anyway and took over my life. I was seven, so it's not